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CHENNAI KIDNAPPING**Vikas, 23**

Student of Satyabhama University in Chennai, he was kidnapped in south Chennai along with his friend Adyar. Sanjiv Kumar Singh alias Kolti, 26, who kidnapped the two was a former student of the same college.



spicuous hate and consumption" within families, fuelled by unfair distribution of power and wealth. "There is lot of hidden coercion, violence and incest prevalent in families these days," Visvanathan says. "This is a masked or hidden crime and secrecy is the weapon to carry out these crimes. Because the life of the kidnapped is at stake in most cases, the matter never gets reported," says Rajat Mitra, a crime psychologist based in Delhi who has counselled 50 cases of in-house kidnapping. Even in Vaishnavi's case, who was first kidnapped four years ago with money allegedly paid for her release, her father had denied enmity with anyone, indicating the tendency to keep the feud within the family.

In Chennai last year, a 30-year-old doctor, Suresh, was caught after he kidnapped his engineer cousin Shailaja (name changed), 23, allegedly to convince her to marry him. The police are now in a dilemma because the girl's parents have refused to file

a complaint against Suresh, fearing that if the matter becomes public it will be difficult to get her married. In another case, the son of an IAS officer of Madhya Pradesh cadre and student of Satyabhama University in Chennai, Vikas, 23, was kidnapped with his friend Adyar by Sanjiv Kumar Singh alias Kolti, 26, who was a former student of the same college which has the reputation of attracting rich students from northern states.

As police help is not taken in most of these cases, the true estimate of the number of kidnappings is elusive. Nandy says that unless there is reliable data, conclusions are hard to be made on the sociological aspects. But some statistics underline the enormity of the problem. According to National Crime Records Bureau's latest report, 27,561 cases of kidnapping and abduction were reported during 2007—an increase of about 15 per cent over 2006. The data for Delhi is quite revealing and worrisome. Of the 33 reported kidnappings



"The boys who indulge in these acts have an element of criminality, as they are not fearful of the consequences."

RAJAT MITRA,
Crime psychologist



"Staging one's own kidnapping is a reaction by children who can't take 'no' from their parents."

RAKESH MARIA
JCP (crime), Mumbai